



Aman outperformed North Macedonia's 2022 European champion Vladimir Egorov and upset Albanian wrestler and 2022 World champion Zelimkhan Abakarov, who reportedly struggled with weight-cutting issues, by technical superiority. However, he was overpowered by eventual champion Rei Higuchi of Japan in the semifinals.

As Iranian Worlds silver medallist Alireza Sarlak did not make weight, Aman, who worked hard to shed 4.6 kg in 10 hours, avoided a potentially strong rival in the repechage round and easily defeated Puerto Rico's Darian Cruz in the bronze medal match, making history at the Champ de Mars arena.

"Since I have won a bronze medal, I will try to win a gold next time," said Aman, who idolises Sushil.

Aman managed to speak with Sushil and received valuable tips ahead of his bronze medal match.

"After seeing Sushil Pehelwan for the first time some years ago, I thought, 'If he can win two Olympic medals, why can't I win one?' I spoke to him. He said I fought well in the quarterfinals but gave away too much space in the semifinals. He advised me to forget the past and give my

best in the bronze medal match," Aman shared.

Vinesh, the Outlier

Earlier, a determined and focussed Vinesh — one of the leading voices in the wrestlers' protest last year — dropped down to the 50kg weight category due to uncertainty about her ability to challenge quota place winner Antim Panghal for the 53kg slot, especially in the absence of a properly functioning Wrestling Federation of India (WFI).

The two-time World bronze medallist stunned World and Olympic champion Yui Susaki in the opening round, advancing to the final. However, the next morning took an unexpected turn when Vinesh was disqualified. Heartbroken, she announced her retirement soon after.

With Vinesh taking her case to the Court of Arbitration for Sport (CAS), uncertainty surrounding her future lingered beyond the Games.

India, which had secured two wrestling medals in Tokyo, faced further setbacks. Nisha Dahiya suffered an injury during her 68kg quarterfinal bout, leading to her elimination.

World bronze medallist Antim

Disappointing start: Antim

Panghal's much-awaited Olympic debut at Paris 2024 ended with a first-round defeat in the women's 53kg wrestling event at the Champ-de-Mars Arena. ^{AP}

(53kg) also struggled with weight management and suffered a surprising loss to Turkey's double European bronze medallist Zeynep Yetgil. Anshu Malik (57kg), a 2021 World Championships silver medallist, had sustained a shoulder injury before the Games and was eliminated by former Olympic champion Helen Maroulis of the USA.

Reetika Hooda, the World U-23 champion in the 76kg category, defeated two-time European bronze medallist Bernadett Nagy before falling to Kyrgyzstan's top-seeded Aiperi Medet Kyzy, a World silver medallist.

The WFI must acknowledge the wrestlers' performance in the Paris Olympics and initiate efforts to elevate the sport's standards. It is crucial to restore trust between the federation and the wrestlers while devising solid plans to get Indian wrestling back on track with the 2028 Olympics in mind.